mariyadai or ‘self-respect’, based on social equality, was unique to Tamil culture and could be traced back to the Sangam Age. He further held Brahmin ideology to be responsible for the oppression of the lower castes, and led a series of what were intended to be non-violent protests against discriminatory caste laws and practices (of which more in a later chapter).

Accompanying this growing distrust of what was now increasingly viewed as Brahminical propaganda was the desire to restore Tamil culture to its pre-Arya state of supposed perfection. In 1909 an article entitled ‘The Morality of the Ramayana’ was published in the *Malabar Quarterly Review*, based on the work of a recently deceased scholar and Tamil playwright, Sundaram Pillai, who attacked Valmiki’s *Ramayana* as being written ‘to proclaim the powers of the Aryans, and to represent their rivals and enemies the Dravidians, who had attained a high degree of civilisation at that period, in the worst possible colour’.[12] This was eagerly seized upon by Periyar, who for the remainder of his long political struggle used it as an example of Arya oppression, culminating in his placing a garland of slippers on a portrait of Rama and then burning it in public. His book *The Ramayana: A True Reading*, published in 1959, is still banned in the northern state of Uttar Pradesh.

A further by-product of this Tamil revivalism was the promotion of the sage Agathya as the father of the Tamil nation, despite the protests of a number of Tamil intellectuals who recognised it as pure fiction. One such critic was the historiographer K. N. Sivaraja Pillai, a lecturer at the University of Madras. Pillai examined all the evidence relating to Agastya and published his findings in two monographs published in the early 1930s, *Agastya in the Tamil Land* and *The Chronology of the Early Tamils*, texts that I would recommend to any Tamil who sees Agathya as